
The 10 Best Jazz Albums of 2025

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It's been a good year for jazz, diverse in every way—styles, influences, tastes, and demographics too. I didn't aim the list to turn out this way, but four of the albums' leaders are women, and five (including three of those four) feature prominent female "sidemen." There's old and young, with the leaders' ages ranging from 38 (Sullivan Fortner) to 87 (Charles Lloyd), the rest widely spaced in between. Seven of the 10 albums were released by indie labels, four of them on labels that are also artist-owned (two on Pyroclastic, one each on Greenleaf and Yes). Finally, for audiophiles, all of the albums *sound* very good, most of them terrifically vivid, and half are available on finely mastered vinyl. They all supply much-needed pleasure, in varying ways.

Mary Halvorson is having her moment. Downbeat magazine's newly published critics' poll ranks her as the No. 1 guitarist of the year, and her sextet, Amaryllis, as the No. 1 group of the year. Right on cue, her latest sextet album, *About Ghosts*, is a triumph. She's been at least intriguing since she first came on the scene as a fearless 27-year-old back in 2008, splashing new colors on the jazz skies with her crystalline intonation, oddball intervals, and wavering harmonies, clearly influenced more by Hendrix and avant-garde horn players than by any bebop guitarists. Her early works were a mixed bag: riveting themes, often drifting into aimless improvs. But in recent years, she has figured out how to lace her ideas with structure, and *About Ghosts*, in that sense, is a triumph, marking her stature as a truly original musician, bandleader, and composer—a master in a style of her own invention. Her bandmates are top notch and clued in, their interplay is clairvoyant, and the music overall is a head-spinner. More than that, it's fun.

Yes, Halvorson grabs the list's top two slots, this one in duets with pianist Sylvie Courvoisier. As composers, they alternate tracks: Halvorson wrote the opener, Courvoisier the next piece, and so forth. Their approaches are distinct—Halvorson's stressing crooked pathways, Courvoisier's modern-classical harmonies—but both teem with playful wit and indigo beauty.

This is Fred Hersch's first piano-trio album in seven years and thus marks a return to form in more than one sense. A lithely virtuosic pianist, peerlessly lyrical, Hersch runs more energetic strides than usual, galvanized by drummer Joey Baron's [klook-a-mop](#) polyrhythms and the firmly agile anchor of bassist Drew Gress. The music is a mix of originals and standards. Standouts are a simmering take on Ornette Coleman's "Law Years" and an inventive cover of "Embraceable You" that starts off with a free-ranging improv and moves gradually into the melody.

I once described Sullivan Fortner's piano style as "[Erroll Garner channeled through Chico Marx](#)," and though he still exudes that exuberant charm, he's widened his range, sharpened his wit, and deepened his mastery. He is simply one of the best jazz pianists playing. The opener and title tune of *Southern Nights*—recorded with bassist Peter Washington and drummer Marcus Gilmore—begins with breezy strums of the strings inside the piano, follows with syncopated sparkles on the keyboard, then angles into the song with the soulful hipness of Dr. John: It's one of the coolest piano-trio tracks in ages.

Patricia Brennan ranks among the best jazz vibraphonists since Bobby Hutcherson, and her new album is something else entirely. According to her liner notes, she composed its seven tracks by collecting "pitch and numerical data from constellations" in the night sky, then overlaying them onto the [circle of fifths](#). That may sound dry, but the resulting music—a blend of 20th-century classical, avant jazz, and a Latin tinge, overflowing with adventure, spattered with blues—is anything but. Brennan, now 40, was a child prodigy, born and raised in Mexico on the classics, Hendrix, and

Radiohead, playing in her teens with the likes of Yo-Yo Ma and Simon Rattle, moving to New York in the 2000s, finding alliances since with fellow eclectics. (She plays in Halvorson's sextet, and Courvoisier, Halvorson's duet partner, is a member of the 10-piece band on this album.) This is a gemstone in the mosaic of today's music.

At age 83, composer-pianist-organist-singer Amina Claudine Myers remains an artist of graceful depths. She's a veteran of the Association for the Advancement of Creative Musicians, the collective of Black avant-gardists that formed in Chicago in the '60s and has influenced modern jazz ever since, but her spins are more accessible—more grounded in spirituals. This solo album consists of one standard ("Steal Away") and nine originals, several of which she's recorded before, though the versions here are more meditative and probing.

David Murray was *the* tenor saxophonist of the 1980s and early-to-mid '90s, a key figure in the vital World Saxophone Quartet, the leader of a dozen other bands, featured on almost 100 albums. Then he decamped to Paris, reappearing now and then, returning for good just a few years ago. At age 70, he still has that magic sound: the smoky vibrato, straight out of Ben Webster, mixed with the improvisational zest of Sonny Rollins and the frantic flurries of John Coltrane or Albert Ayler. He has settled into a durable quartet, his best in 20 years, thanks largely to pianist Marta Sanchez, whose harmonies are as deeply rooted in Ravel and Debussy as in Wayne Shorter and Andrew Hill.

Trumpeter Dave Douglas was a stellar figure in the pack of talented Young Turks who enlivened the "downtown" jazz scene in the early 1990s, as a member of John Zorn's Masada and leader of a dozen bands on his own. Now, at 62, he's practically an *éminence grise*, mentoring novices on the rise, yet retaining his verve of yore. On *Alloy*, he unselfishly shares the front line with two new trumpeters (Alexandra Ridout and Dave Adewumi) and a debut bassist (Kate Pass), while joined with his longtime frequent drummer Rudy Royston and the great vibist (see above) Patricia Brennan. An alloy, as he writes in his liner notes, is a blending of elements to create a new and stronger substance, and that's what we have here—a *mélange* of spirituals, ballads, up-tempo rousers, and a couple of tunes that mix them all. It's a voyage.

At age 87, Charles Lloyd isn't the oldest still-active jazz saxophonist, but he is the oldest who can still blow a gorgeous whole note and navigate arpeggios with a steady grace. His music swoons with festive beauty and a soulful blues that shields it from sentimentality. This is a bare-bones trio album—Lloyd with pianist Jason Moran and guitarist Marvin Sewell—playing 98 minutes of originals and standards, including pieces dedicated to Duke Ellington, Langston Hughes, Zakir Hussain, Billie Holiday, and Leonard Bernstein. Lloyd & Co. set a mood and stir it satisfyingly.

Moran, our most accomplished jazz pianist, rounds out the year with his most unusual project, a collaboration with Norway's leading jazz ensemble, its leader, Ole Morten Vågan, arranging an array of Moran tunes plus Jaki Byard's "Out Front" and Brahms' Intermezzo op. 118, no. 2. I prefer Moran's own arrangements, either with his Bandwagon trio or occasional larger ensembles (such as the bands he formed to pay tribute to Thelonious Monk and James Reese Europe), but these pieces are lively, and Moran stays up front on piano, which makes any album more than worthwhile. (This is currently available only online from Bandcamp; Moran will release it as a disc on his Yes label next year.)

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